merchants felt that ‘on various occasions’ the treatment accorded to them by ‘the subordinates’ of the British company was ‘unfair and oppressive’. Representations were therefore made to both the local agents of the company, A. & F. Harvey, and the Calcutta Agents, Mackinnon, Mackenzie and Company. Receiving no positive response, the merchants informed BI, sometime in early 1906 (the date is not specified), that they would be forced to start a navigation company of their own. When this fell on deaf ears once again, the merchants decided to carry out their threat. Initially, the local merchants agreed among themselves to charter a steamer from Bombay. They constituted ‘a syndicate’, as the SSNCo’s annual report called it, and chartered a steamer from the Shah Line Company ‘for a short period’.[19]

More than a decade after the events detailed in this book, these hardships and humiliations continued to rankle in their minds. S.D. Krishna Aiyangar—who became the honorary secretary of SSNCo a year after its foundation and helmed the company after VOC’s imprisonment in March 1908—while giving evidence to the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee in 1924, said:

> The shippers were complaining to the B.I. about the claims due to them on account of shortage in particular matters; and they were not being respectably treated by the B.I. The shippers did not receive a sympathetic reply from the B.I.; and therefore, they were contemplating to charter a steamer or to own some steamers, especially because the sphere of their operation was very limited. The merchants were sending their cargo only from Tuticorin to Colombo. As their business was very limited, they thought they could successfully run a line. They came to certain English-educated gentlemen regarding legal advice. Except giving legal advice, the educated people took no part in the affair.[20]

With an ascendant Swadeshi movement providing the spur, the humiliated merchants rallied together and sought the help of politically aware lawyers—though S.D. Krishna Aiyangar uses the plural, VOC was the man in the vanguard—to take the matter in their own hands. The establishment of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company was the result.

